the height of its civilisation, the unchallenged mistress of the world, with all the qualities that had made it great most in evidence. The upper classes were secure in their inheritance and adding to it, with little fear of a successful challenge. It was the age of a growing liberalism and a firm belief in a great destiny. It is not surprising that the Indians who went there were fascinated by this imposing spectacle. More Hindus went there to begin with and they returned admirers of Europe and England. Gradually they got used to the shine and glamour, and the first surprise wore off. But in Sir Syed's case that first surprise and fascination is very much in evidence. Visiting England in 1869, he wrote letters home giving his impressions. In one of these he stated: "The result of all this is that although I do not absolve the English in India of discourtesy, and of looking upon the natives of that country as animals and beneath contempt, I think they do so from not understanding us; and I am afraid I must confess that they are not far wrong in their opinion of us. Without flattering the English, I can truly say that the natives of India, high and low, merchants and petty shopkeepers, educated and illiterate, when contrasted with the English in education, manners and uprightness, are as like them as a dirty animal is to an able and handsome man. The English have reason for believing us in India to be imbecile brutes. . . . What I have seen, and seen daily, is utterly beyond the imagination of a native of India. . . . All good things, spiritual and worldly, which should be found in man, have been bestowed by the Almighty on Europe, and especially on England."[1]

Greater praise no man could give to the British and to Europe, and it is obvious that Sir Syed was tremendously impressed. Perhaps also he used strong language and heightened the contrasts in order to shake up his own people out of their torpor and induce them to take a step forward. This step, he was convinced, must be in the direction of Western education; without that education his community would become more and more backward and powerless. English education meant government jobs, security, influence, honour. So to this education he turned all his energy, trying to win over his community to his way of thinking. He wanted no diversions or distractions from other directions; it was a difficult enough piece of work to overcome the inertia and hesitation of the Muslims. The beginnings of a new nationalism, sponsored by the Hindu *bourgeoisie*, seemed to him to offer such a distraction, and he

[1] This quotation has been taken from Hans Kohn's *History of Nationalism in the East.*